

AUSTERITY CHAMP

Few NDA allies have embraced Prime Minister Narendra Modi's austerity call as earnestly as Telugu Desam Party (TDP) chief **Chandrababu Naidu**. The Andhra Pradesh CM quickly halved his convoy as a fuel-saving measure, and then went a step further—the TDP's annual Mahanadu conclave was a virtual event this year. The 2026 edition had been planned with 500,000 partymen attending. Instead, top TDP leaders converged at the party's swanky new HQ at Mangalagiri, near capital Amaravati, and the deliberations were streamed live at 1,875 Mahanadu clusters across the state.

No Vacancy



For months, Uttarakhand BJP circles had been buzzing with rumours over whether CM **Pushkar Singh Dhami** would remain the party's face for 2027. The BJP leadership appears to have closed the door on the subject for any potential challengers. During his Uttarakhand visit, BJP president Nitin Nabin not only praised Dhami's government but also explicitly declared that the party would return to power in 2027 under his leadership. He even spoke of a 'Dhami model'. With the election just a year away, Delhi seems keen to ensure that the party doesn't lose focus discussing possible challengers.

PAWAR CONNECTION



There was one name in the BJP candidates list for the Maharashtra legislative council polls that caught the eye of a lot many people. **Arun Lakhani**, the party nominee from the Wardha-Chandrapur-Gadchiroli seat, is soon to be linked to the Pawar family by marriage. This month, Lakhani's son Sarang will marry Revati, daughter of Opposition NCP (SCP) MP **Supriya Sule**, and granddaughter of party patriarch Sharad Pawar. Political observers will be watching to see if the wedding *mandap* becomes a venue for backchannel talks.

Kaushik Deka **with** ***Ashish Misra, Amitabh Srivastava, Prasad Nichenametla, Avaneesh Mishra*** **and** ***Dhaval S. Kulkarni***

ECO WATCH

CANINE DISEASE OUTBREAK
THE GIR LION KILLER

By **Jumana Shah**

Eleven Asiatic lions, many of them cubs, have died this May in Gujarat's Gir region from a suspected outbreak of canine distemper virus (CDV) and babesiosis. State forests minister Arjun Modhwadia said vaccination, de-ticking and isolation drives were under way on a "war footing". Over 350 lions have been 'de-ticked' so far; 17 displaying symptoms have been isolated.



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Initially, the deaths were attributed to babesiosis, an infectious disease transmitted by a tick-borne protozoan parasite that destroys red blood cells and causes severe anaemia. Since then, CDV has also been blamed. The pairing is ominous. Between September and November 2018, a combined CDV-babesiosis outbreak killed at least 23 lions in Gir East. The National Institute of Virology sequenced a near-complete CDV genome and found it related to the strain that wiped out 1,000 lions in Tanzania's Serengeti in 1994.

CDV recurs in Gir because the transmission pathway is integral to the region's lion landscape. Free-ranging dogs are the primary link; lions encounter and prey on them at the forest-village interface, typically while scavenging on livestock carcasses. The 2025 census put Gujarat's lion population at 891, but only 55.8 per cent live in forest areas. The remaining 44.2 per cent move around in human inhabited lands. Amreli district, where the current deaths are concentrated, holds 332 lions, the largest population outside Gir National Park.

In April 2013, the Supreme Court had ordered the translocation of a few prides to Kuno-Palpur Wildlife Sanctuary in Madhya Pradesh, citing precisely this epidemic risk. Thirteen years on, not one lion has been shifted. Kuno now hosts African cheetahs.